
Modern Behaviours & Engagement Plan

The interaction layer — premium, never gimmicky

The interaction layer that makes the portfolio feel alive and expensive — without ever feeling gimmicky or janky. Read alongside the section roadmap in `PORTFOLIO_V4_EXECUTION_PLAN.md`.

How to read this: each idea has **what it is**, **why it engages**, **fit** (does it match the slim/premium, no-cheap-AI north star), and **effort**. Priorities: **P0** = do now, high impact; **P1** = strong, soon; **P2** = optional/experimental; **AVOID** = looks cheap, skip.

✓ Already live (the premium behaviours we built)

- **Scroll-driven "presents itself" entrances** (`animation-timeline: view()`) — Proof section resolves as you scroll in.
- **Pen-draw charts** — the Proof line draws point-by-point (~2.5s).
- **Glass metric cards** — gold halo glow + left-to-right **shine-sweep** + idle float + **count-up** numbers.
- **Skills carousel** — auto-advance + arrows + drag/swipe + keyboard + dots + pause; per-card animated graphs + real AI background atmospheres.
- **Pinned-scroll storytelling** — the Work section (left pins, right scrolls).
- **Custom cursor, magnetic CTA, reduced-motion safety** throughout.

This is already top ~5% behaviour. The list below is how we push to top 1%.

🎯 THE ASK: control the carousel with the scroll wheel

What it is: when the pointer is **over the Skills carousel**, the mouse wheel / trackpad advances the cards sideways instead of (or before) scrolling the page.

Why it engages: it turns a passive scroll into a tactile "I'm driving this" moment — premium and modern (Apple/Linear-style).

The safe rule (critical — or it feels like a trap): - Horizontal trackpad swipe (`deltaX`) → moves the carousel natively. Always. - Vertical wheel while hovering → advance **one card per gesture** with a short cooldown — but **release to the page** the moment there are no more cards in that direction (no dead-end scroll-jacking). - Pause auto-advance while the user is driving; resume after a beat. - Respect `prefers-reduced-motion` (no capture) and touch (native swipe already works).

Fit: ✓ premium. **Effort:** small (one handler in `initSkills`). **Priority: P0** — I'll add it on top of the perfected carousel.

Po — do now (high impact, on-brand)

Behaviour	What it is	Why it engages	Effort
Wheel/trackpad carousel control	the ask above	tactile control	S
Cursor-follow spotlight on cards	a soft gold light that tracks the pointer across the hovered card surface	makes the card feel lit and reactive	S
Neighbour-dim on hover	hovered card lifts + sharpens; siblings dim/desaturate slightly	directs the eye, feels curated	S
Active-card focus in carousel	the centred card is brighter/larger; off-centre cards recede	depth + a clear "hero" at all times	S–M

P1 — strong, soon

Behaviour	What it is	Why it engages	Effort
Subtle 3D tilt	cards/photos tilt a few degrees toward the cursor (parallax)	physicality without gimmick	S
Scroll-progress accent	a 2px gold progress line at the very top of the page	quiet "you're making progress" cue	S
Magnetic dots/arrows	carousel controls gently pull toward the cursor	premium micro-feel	S
Text mask reveals	headlines wipe/clip in on entry (not just fade)	editorial, high-status	S
Sticky "Let's talk" after Proof	the CTA quietly docks once they've seen the proof	conversion at peak trust	M
Copy-to-clipboard contact	click email/handle → copies + a soft toast	frictionless, modern	S

P2 — optional / experimental (try, keep only if it stays classy)

Behaviour	What it is	Note
Pinned scroll-scrub carousel	pin Skills and scrub cards with scroll (Apple-style)	powerful but conflicts with the "one-view compact" goal — only if we change that decision
Live timezone chip	"available across India · Dubai · USA" with a real local-time tick	real, subtle credibility
Hover-to-reveal source	hover a stat → a tiny "where this number comes from" line	reinforces "numbers are real"

Behaviour	What it is	Note
Ambient section backdrop	the <code>skl-bg-ambient.webp</code> faint behind the whole Skills band	extra depth

✗ AVOID (these read cheap / hurt the brand)

- Heavy parallax on everything, cursor trails, confetti, bouncing emojis.
- Auto-playing sound or video with sound.
- Full scroll-jacking that traps the page; long fake loaders.
- Tilt/zoom so strong it feels like a toy.
- Any AI-stock 3D imagery (the whole point is bespoke, coded motion).

🛡 Guardrails (so "modern" never becomes "janky")

- **GPU-only** motion (transform/opacity/stroke) — never animate layout.
- **Reduced-motion** path for every effect (final state, no auto-move).
- **Never trap scroll** — always release at boundaries.
- **One signature motion per section** — stack micro-interactions, not competing big moves.
- **Mobile = calm** — heavy hover effects are pointer-only; touch stays simple.
- Verify each on real Chrome (desktop + phone) before it ships.

Suggested order

1. **P0 set** on the freshly-perfected Skills carousel (wheel control, cursor spotlight, neighbour-dim, active-card focus).
2. **P1 conversion + polish** (sticky CTA after Proof, copy-to-clipboard, scroll-progress, text reveals) — these lift hire/convert.
3. **P2** only the ones that test classy.

Then resume the section roadmap (`PORTFOLIO_V4_EXECUTION_PLAN.md`): Case Studies → Process (turn the dead stepper on) → About → Contact → privacy pass.